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“I’m an outdoors guy, being outside all day and driving tractors and being in the dirt. That’s just kind of who I am. So if I can come to church and do the same thing, getting in my own element, outside and not in a building, it’s just good.”

ANDY GUSTAFSON, who says he feels at home at the Ogle County Cowboy Church



SALVATION WITH A TWANG

On horseback, under a nearly cloudless blue sky, the pastor removed his cowboy hat and bowed his head, speaking to the Lord during an unconventional Sunday worship service hosted by a nascent Christian ministry in northwest Illinois.

“I pray that this time may be blessed,” he said, closing his eyes and holding the reins in one hand. “I pray that you watch over everybody here. And I just thank you that we get to do this. This is insane. I just ask that your message would come forth.”

After the blessing concluded, the crowd of around 140 responded “amen” from the wooden bleachers of the horse arena at the Ogle County Fairgrounds in Oregon, roughly two hours west of Chicago.

The pastor, Kerry Hughes, led the service in jeans and cowboy

boots, no clerical collar or vestments.

Many of the worshippers were similarly dressed, some donning sneakers, shorts, riding boots or their work clothes.

A church advertisement for the event had instructed them to forego their “Sunday best” in

favor of something a little more comfortable.

This is cowboy church — a unique form of worship using Western culture and rural life-style to share the Bible, part of a broader movement of similarly country-themed congregations and ministries scattered across

the United States, primarily in the South.

Founded by Hughes and a small group of like-minded worshippers, the Ogle County Cowboy Church held its first service in late September 2025.

Most Sundays, they meet inside a historic college chapel in Mount Morris, a nearby rural town of just under 3,000 residents.

But the 53-year-old pastor said he prefers to preach and pray in more rustic spaces. Barns. Machine sheds. Horse arenas.

His favorite sanctuary for worship is outdoors, among “God’s creation.”

“I’m not much into brick and stained glass,” he added.

So during favorable seasons of weather, worshippers gather

See **CHURCH** on Page A10

A failure to close funeral home

Missed opportunities preceded discovery of bodies at facility

By Gregory Royal Pratt, Olivia Olander, Caroline Kubzansky, Talia Soglin, Sam Charles, Dan Petrella and Madeline Buckley
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After city and state officials discovered 56 decomposing bodies in a Chicago funeral home, Gov. JB Pritzker defended the state’s response to complaints against the husband and wife in charge of the facility.

Pritzker’s message, delivered during a downstate event, was simple: State government did its job.

The comptroller’s office, he said, “did what they should do” in shutting down a notorious crematorium run by the same family in the south suburbs where mishandled bodies and hundreds of unreturned remains were discovered in 2025.

The licensing board, he said, “did what it is supposed to do” about the pair who also were running South Chicago Chapel, where the most recent discovery was made.

The people who didn’t do what’s right, Pritzker said, were the couple, Clark and Johanna Morgan.

“We’re talking about some really bad actors,” Pritzker said. “The process was followed, the process that’s in the law now, and obviously there was no report that came in that would lead anybody to discover this” until late last month, he added at another recent news conference.

A Tribune investigation, however, found regulatory shortcomings that allowed those apparently bad actors to persist, with the state failing to fully shut down Clark and Johanna Morgan’s businesses or take their licenses even after they were found to have mishandled human remains at

See **REMAINS** on Page A6

Tobias Feick, from left, Nathaniel Davis and Malachi Voight bow their heads in prayer during Ogle County Cowboy Church’s “Church in the Dirt” at the Ogle County Fairgrounds in downstate Oregon on July 12. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

■ South Chicago Chapel families may never know the truth about the cremated remains of loved ones, experts say. **Chicagoland, Page A8**

INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Learning on the job

Rookies and backups carried the load on both sides of the ball Saturday in the Bears’ preseason opener, a 34-10 domination of the Browns at a drizzly Soldier Field. **Coverage in Sports**

DEATH OF HORSE RACING

Now that Chicagoland racing has been pronounced dead, the autopsy reveals trouble started with poor decisions made decades ago. **Page A12**

WET ENOUGH FOR YOU?

Chicagoland’s wild, wet and severe summer has left plenty of destruction. But none of this year’s months rank among the wettest in history. **Page B4**

As pesticides drift onto state schools, parks, residents urge better tracking

By Christiana Freitag
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

TREMONT, Ill. — On her 43 acres of woods and reclaimed native prairie in rural Tazewell County, Katie VandenBerg walked the edge of her property, inspecting a line of oaks bordered by miles of corn and soybean fields.

The oak leaves are curled and stunted — damage she believes is tied to pesticide applications on nearby farms.

Since buying the land three years ago, VandenBerg, whose family has lived in Tazewell County for seven generations, said she has “gone down a rabbit hole” trying to understand how drifting chemicals are affecting her trees.

Then, this spring, that threat reached her 10-year-old daughter, Genevieve.

Hundreds of children had gathered outside Bethel Lutheran School in nearby Morton for a



Oak leaves that border a nearby farm field curl with repeated exposure to pesticides on property belonging to Katie VandenBerg, back, on Aug. 3 in Tremont. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

jump-rope fundraiser when a chemical odor swept across the parking lot. Across the street, according to Illinois Department of Agriculture records, farmer

Mark Eigsti was spraying pesticides on his soybean fields as wind gusts topped 19 miles per hour.

See **TRACKING** on Page A4

90%

Over six years, Prairie Rivers Network researchers detected herbicides in more than 90% of 127 plant tissue samples they collected from a variety of sites. And during a stretch in 2025, pesticides were found more than 200 times in 10 public Illinois locations.

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